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Intelligence Briefing

Europe

May 23, 2026

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY (BLUF)

Ukraine's defensive operations are stabilizing the frontline and inflicting unsustainable casualties on Russian forces, with over 1,000 daily losses in 2026. The Kremlin remains committed to maximalist war aims despite internal recognition of a strategic dead end, while leveraging nuclear exercises with Belarus to signal resolve and distract from battlefield weaknesses.

KEY DEVELOPMENTS

- Ukraine's defensive operations are yielding territorial gains and inflicting over 1,000 Russian casualties per day in 2026.
- Russian strategic nuclear exercises with Belarus signal willingness to escalate and deepen Minsk's subordination.
- Ukrainian long-range strikes hit critical Russian defense industrial and energy targets near Moscow.
- Kremlin acknowledges strategic dead end but refuses to alter maximalist war aims.
- Russia fails to finalize Power of Siberia-2 pipeline deal with China, exposing limits of bilateral cooperation.

MILITARY OPERATIONS

Ukraine continues to hold and locally recapture territory, aided by the loss of Russian access to Starlink in February 2026 and Ukraine's intensifying long-range strike campaign against Russian logistics and defense industry targets. Ukrainian forces struck the Angstrom Semiconductor Plant near Moscow, the Moscow Oil Refinery, and multiple oil pumping stations on May 16-17, disrupting Russian supply chains. Russia responded with a large-scale drone and missile strike on May 17-18 using 546 munitions, including 14 ballistic missiles, targeting energy and civilian infrastructure, particularly in Dnipro and Dnipropetrovsk oblasts. Ukraine's new domestically produced guided glide bomb will enhance battlefield air interdiction capabilities.

Sources:

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 22, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 21, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 20, 2026

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 19, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 18, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 17, 2026
- Ukraine's Fortress Belt: The Key to Sustaining the Frontline

NUCLEAR POSTURE AND BELARUS INTEGRATION

Russia and Belarus completed combined nuclear exercises on May 21, involving the deployment of nuclear munitions to Belarus and launches of ICBMs, hypersonic missiles, and cruise missiles. The exercises, unannounced and held earlier than usual, included over 64,000 personnel and demonstrated Russia's deepening de facto control over Belarus. The Belarusian constitution was amended in 2022 to renounce non-nuclear status, and future Union Shield exercises in 2027 may include a nuclear component. These actions serve as strategic signaling to Ukraine's allies amid mounting battlefield pressures.

Sources:

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 21, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 19, 2026

POLITICAL AND STRATEGIC DEVELOPMENTS

Western officials and intelligence assessments confirm that Ukraine is gaining territory and stabilizing the front, while Bloomberg reports that senior Kremlin officials believe the war has reached a 'dead end' with no clear resolution. However, President Putin remains committed to seizing all of Donetsk and Luhansk oblasts by end of 2026, rejecting any compromise. Russia's failure to secure an agreement on the Power of Siberia-2 pipeline during Putin's visit to China highlights limits in the Sino-Russian partnership, as China leverages its position to extract concessions. Meanwhile, Russian occupation authorities continue forced integration of Ukrainian territories through child deportations, cultural programs, and economic absorption.

Sources:

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 22, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 20, 2026
- Russian Occupation Update, May 21, 2026

OUTLOOK

Ukraine will likely continue to leverage its Fortress Belt defensive advantages and deep strike capabilities to degrade Russian offensive potential, while Russia may escalate non-nuclear strategic attacks and propaganda campaigns to exert pressure on Western support. The risk of further nuclear signaling or limited tactical nuclear use remains low but cannot be dismissed.

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